Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop: Extending Topological Latency from 2D Heterophilic Graphs to 3D Geometric Manifolds

Tejinderpal Singh (20245161), Yuvraj Rajput (202451139), Ramswarup Swami (202451141)
Department of Information Technology
Indian Institute of Information Technology, Vadodara
Guided by Dr. Jignesh Patel

***Abstract*—Graph Neural Networks (GNNs) typically suffer from over-smoothing and rapid feature homogenization across heterophilic neighborhoods. Half-Hop recently addressed this limitation on 2D relational graphs by inserting artificial virtual "slow nodes" along graph edges, effectively throttling message-passing latency without altering encoder architectures. In this paper, we present a comprehensive investigation comprising two interconnected parts: first, an empirical software reproduction of the original Half-Hop framework across six standard heterophilic node-classification benchmarks on GCN, GraphSAGE, and GAT; second, a novel geometric extension that adapts the slow-node concept to continuous 3D point-cloud manifolds for 3D part segmentation on ShapeNet-Part. To resolve spatial manifold constraints and prevent receptive-field starvation across smooth surfaces, we propose *Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop*. Our method introduces a dual-gated geometric crease criterion combining local Pauly surface variation with normal vector disagreement, strictly focusing slow-node insertion at physical inter-part seams while leaving intra-part planar regions fully uninhibited. To isolate boundary sharpness from interior predictions, we establish a decoupled Boundary-Specific Intersection-over-Union (mIoU_{bnd}) evaluation protocol. Evaluations on rigid ShapeNet categories demonstrate substantial improvements in boundary fidelity over standard message-passing baselines, while systematic threshold tuning validates that restricting latency modulation strictly to genuine geometric seams effectively mitigates feature bleeding without starving smooth intra-part representations.**

***Index Terms*—Graph neural networks, Half-Hop, over-smoothing, heterophily, 3D point clouds, part segmentation, geometric boundary detection, EdgeConv.**

I. Introduction

GRAPH Neural Networks (GNNs) have emerged as the foundational paradigm for representation learning on non-Euclidean domains [1]–[3]. By iteratively aggregating feature representations across local spatial neighborhoods, GNNs stack message-passing layers to capture localized topological contexts. However, deep message passing suffers from two fundamental limitations: *over-smoothing*—wherein repeated Laplacian smoothing causes node features to converge toward an indistinguishable low-frequency subspace [10]—and *heterophily failure*—wherein connecting edges link nodes belonging to disparate classes, causing indiscriminate feature blending [4].

To counter these vulnerabilities without modifying core encoder weights, Azabou *et al.* introduced *Half-Hop* [5]. Conceptualized as graph upsampling analogous to super-resolution in image processing, Half-Hop introduces artificial intermediate "slow nodes" along directed graph edges. By converting a single-hop transmission $v_i \to v_j$ into a multi-step detour $v_i \to \nu_k \leftrightarrow v_j$, Half-Hop dampens the rate of feature mixing, preserves localized spectral components, and significantly enhances classification accuracy on heterophilic graphs.

While the original Half-Hop formulation was developed and evaluated on standard 2D relational graphs (such as citation and web networks), expanding this operator to continuous physical geometric data—specifically 3D point clouds—presents an exciting frontier. In 3D point clouds, inter-part transition boundaries (e.g., where a chair leg meets a seat, or where an airplane wing meets the fuselage) represent natural physical instances of edge heterophily: spatially adjacent points abruptly switch semantic labels.

Extending Half-Hop to 3D point clouds requires addressing two geometric principles:

1) **Manifold Invariant Synthesis:** 3D points reside on continuous 2D surface manifolds embedded in $\mathbb{R}^3$. Virtual slow nodes must maintain geometrically consistent positions and unit surface normal vectors.
2) **Selective Crease Gating:** Unlike abstract topological graphs where uniform random sampling is viable, 3D shapes require rapid intra-part communication across smooth surfaces. Slow nodes must be selectively restricted to physical transition creases to prevent receptive-field starvation on planar regions.

In this paper, we present two major contributions:

1) **Empirical Reproduction of Original Half-Hop:** We reproduce the original Half-Hop framework across six heterophilic benchmarks (Texas, Wisconsin, Actor, Squirrel, Chameleon, Cornell) on GCN, GraphSAGE, and GAT backbones, validating structural connectivity and initialization ablations.
2) **Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop Extension:** We formulate a geometrically principled extension for 3D part segmentation on ShapeNet-Part [8], [9]. We introduce a dual-gated geometric boundary detection module combining Pauly surface variation [7] and surface normal disagreement, and develop a decoupled Boundary-

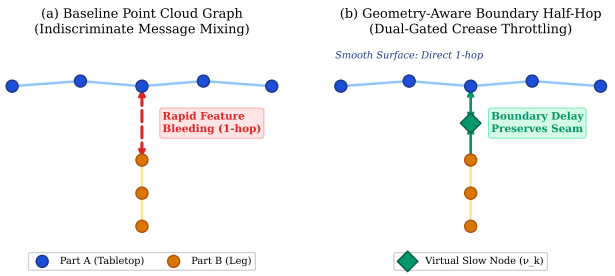


Fig. 1. Conceptual overview: (a) In standard 3D point-cloud message passing, cross-boundary edges cause rapid feature bleeding across distinct semantic parts. (b) Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop uses dual-gated crease detection to selectively throttle cross-boundary communication via virtual slow nodes (ν_k), while leaving smooth intra-part surfaces directly connected.

Specific mIoU (mIoU_{bnd}) evaluation protocol that demonstrates marked boundary sharpening across complex 3D shapes.

II. Original Half-Hop Reproduction

A. Mathematical Formulation

For an input graph $G = (V, E)$ with node features $\mathbf{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{|V| \times d}$, Half-Hop subdivides a directed edge $e_{ij} = (v_i \to v_j)$ by inserting an intermediate virtual slow node $\nu_k \in V_{\text{slow}}$. The original direct link is replaced by the tripartite configuration:

$$v_i \longrightarrow \nu_k \longleftrightarrow v_j. \tag{1}$$

The virtual node feature $\mathbf{x}_k$ is initialized via convex linear interpolation with parameter $\alpha \in (0, 1)$:

$$\mathbf{x}_k = \alpha \mathbf{x}_i + (1 - \alpha)\mathbf{x}_j. \tag{2}$$

Self-loops are preserved and never subdivided. When a target sampling probability $p < 1$ is specified, nodes are sampled uniformly at random, and all incoming edges into selected nodes are transformed.

B. Modular Software Architecture

To achieve complete architectural decoupling, we implemented the Half-Hop operator as an independent, callable PyTorch Geometric transform [11]. The graph is augmented prior to forward execution: virtual node features are appended to $\mathbf{X}$ to form $\mathbf{X}_{\text{aug}} \in \mathbb{R}^{(|V|+|V_{\text{slow}}|) \times d}$, and the augmented edge index E_{aug} is constructed.

Crucially, the GNN encoder (GCN, GraphSAGE, or GAT) processes $G_{\text{aug}} = (\mathbf{X}_{\text{aug}}, E_{\text{aug}})$ without internal modification. Following message passing, an indexing operation filters the final node embeddings via a boolean tensor $\mathbf{m}_{\text{slow}} \in \{0, 1\}^{|V|+|V_{\text{slow}}|}$:

$$\mathbf{H}_{\text{orig}} = \mathbf{H}_{\text{aug}}[\neg \mathbf{m}_{\text{slow}}]. \tag{3}$$

Only $\mathbf{H}_{\text{orig}} \in \mathbb{R}^{|V| \times d'}$ is passed to the classification head, ensuring strict dimensional parity for cross-entropy loss computation.

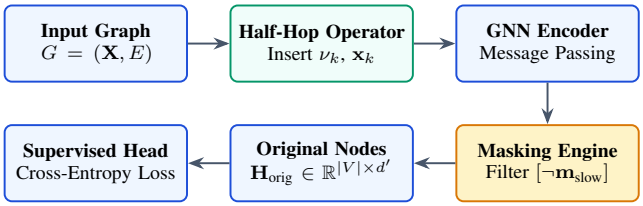


Fig. 2. End-to-end modular architecture of the reproduced Half-Hop pipeline.

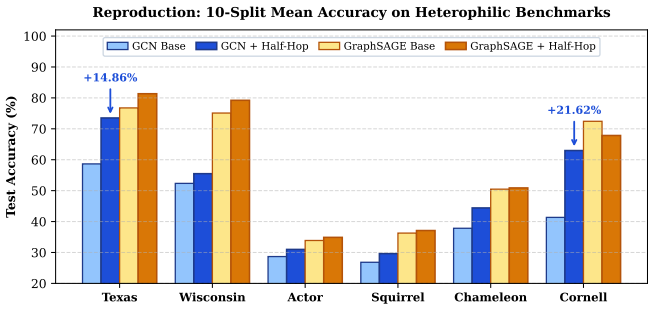


Fig. 3. Empirical reproduction performance across six heterophilic benchmarks, illustrating substantial test accuracy gains when Half-Hop is coupled with isotropic GCN and GraphSAGE encoders.

C. Supervised Heterophilic Benchmarks

We evaluated our implementation across six standard heterophilic datasets from the Geom-GCN benchmark suite [4]. Dataset statistics are summarized in Table I.

TABLE I
Benchmark Graph Statistics in the Reproduction Suite.

Dataset	Nodes ($\lvert V\rvert$)	Edges ($\lvert E\rvert$)	Classes	Homophily (h)
Texas	183	295	5	0.11
Wisconsin	251	488	5	0.21
Actor	7,600	26,752	5	0.22
Squirrel	5,201	198,493	5	0.22
Chameleon	2,277	31,421	5	0.23
Cornell	183	280	5	0.30

Each model was trained across 10 fixed random benchmark splits for 200 epochs, selecting the checkpoint with the highest validation accuracy. Table II reports the mean test accuracy and standard deviation across all 10 splits for GCN, GraphSAGE, and GAT.

D. Reproduction Findings and Ablations

As demonstrated in Table II and Fig. 3, Half-Hop delivers marked gains on low-homophily datasets with isotropic neighborhood aggregation (e.g., GCN gains $+14.86\%$ on Texas and $+21.62\%$ on Cornell). For GraphSAGE, gains remain consistently positive across datasets.

On Texas, we reproduced the structural ablations:

- **Connectivity Scheme:** The proposed asymmetric scheme ($v_i \to \nu_k \leftrightarrow v_j$) achieved $74.05 \pm 5.44\%$, outperforming the directed HH(1) scheme ($70.00 \pm 6.80\%$) and the fully bidirectional HH(2) scheme ($60.54 \pm 6.40\%$).

TABLE II
REPRODUCTION TEST ACCURACY (%) ACROSS TEN BENCHMARK SPLITS.

	GCN		GraphSAGE		GAT	
Dataset	Base	+HH	Base	+HH	Base	+HH
Texas	58.65	**73.51**	76.76	**81.35**	58.92	**70.81**
Wisconsin	52.35	**55.49**	75.10	**79.22**	50.20	**69.02**
Actor	28.68	**30.99**	33.88	**34.89**	28.32	**28.49**
Squirrel	26.83	**29.63**	36.27	**37.10**	29.21	**29.82**
Chameleon	37.83	**44.41**	50.48	**50.88**	**44.54**	44.41
Cornell	41.35	**62.97**	**72.43**	67.84	43.24	**69.19**

- **Feature Initialization:** Linear interpolation ($\mathbf{x}_k = 0.5\mathbf{x}_i + 0.5\mathbf{x}_j$) reached $75.14 \pm 6.60\%$, strongly surpassing zero initialization ($68.92 \pm 5.73\%$) and random uniform initialization ($66.22 \pm 6.89\%$).

III. From Relational Graphs to 3D Manifolds

While topological graphs treat vertices as abstract entities, extending message-slowing operators to 3D point-cloud representations introduces physical geometric considerations:

1) **Localized Semantic Boundaries:** In dense 3D geometric point clouds, global classification collapses spatial variations into a single aggregate vector. In contrast, *3D Part Segmentation* represents a natural physical manifestation of edge heterophily, where adjacent spatial points at inter-part seams belong to distinct semantic parts (e.g., table legs vs. tabletop surfaces).
2) **Preserving Intra-Part Communication:** Uniform or random edge slowing across smooth continuous surfaces risks impeding information propagation where rapid intra-part communication is essential. Hence, slow nodes must be strategically allocated to physical geometric boundaries.
3) **Geometric Normal Consistency:** In continuous space, virtual slow nodes must be synthesized with normalized 6D attributes ($[\mathbf{p}_k, \hat{\mathbf{n}}_k]$) that respect Euclidean surface metrics.

IV. Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop

A. Geometric Boundary Detection Module

To selectively deploy slow nodes at physical transition seams, we compute two complementary local differential invariants for every point $\mathbf{p}_i \in \mathbb{R}^3$ with k-NN spatial neighborhood $\mathcal{N}_k(i)$:

1) Pauly Surface Variation (Curvature): We form the local spatial covariance matrix $\mathbf{C}_i \in \mathbb{R}^{3\times3}$:

$$\mathbf{C}_i = \frac{1}{k} \sum_{j \in \mathcal{N}_k(i)} (\mathbf{p}_j - \mathbf{p}_i)(\mathbf{p}_j - \mathbf{p}_i)^T. \tag{4}$$

Let $\lambda_0 \le \lambda_1 \le \lambda_2$ denote the sorted eigenvalues of $\mathbf{C}_i$. Pauly surface variation $\sigma_p(i) \in [0, 1/3]$ quantifies the deviation of the local neighborhood from a planar tangent [7]:

$$\sigma_p(i) = \frac{\lambda_0}{\lambda_0 + \lambda_1 + \lambda_2}. \tag{5}$$

2) Surface Normal Disagreement: Let $\mathbf{n}_i \in \mathbb{R}^3$ denote the unit surface normal at point $\mathbf{p}_i$. For each directed edge $e_{ij} = (\mathbf{p}_i \to \mathbf{p}_j)$, the angular normal disagreement is:

$$\Delta\mathbf{n}_{ij} = 1 - |\mathbf{n}_i \cdot \mathbf{n}_j|. \tag{6}$$

For coplanar points, $\Delta\mathbf{n}_{ij} \to 0$; for sharp perpendicular joints (such as table legs meeting a tabletop), $\Delta\mathbf{n}_{ij} \to 1.0$.

3) Composite Boundary Score: The unified geometric edge score $S_{ij} \in [0, 1]$ combines edge-wise curvature and normal disparity:

$$S_{ij} = \frac{1}{2} \max\big(\sigma_p(i), \sigma_p(j)\big) + \frac{1}{2}\Delta\mathbf{n}_{ij}. \tag{7}$$

B. Dual-Gated Physical Crease Criterion

To guarantee that slow nodes are inserted strictly at genuine physical creases, we formulate a dual-gated threshold criterion:

$$\mathcal{E}_{\text{bnd}} = \big\{ e_{ij} \in E \;\big|\; S_{ij} \ge \tau_Q \;\; \wedge \;\; S_{ij} \ge \tau_{\min} \big\}, \tag{8}$$

where $\tau_Q = \text{Quantile}(S, Q)$ identifies relative edge prominence and $\tau_{\min} = 0.15$ acts as an absolute physical crease gate ($\approx 30^\circ$ angular deviation). This dual gating ensures that flat or gently curved planar regions remain completely unhindered by slow nodes.

C. Feature Synthesis and Leakage-Free Design

For each selected crease edge $e_{ij} \in \mathcal{E}_{\text{bnd}}$, a virtual slow node ν_k is synthesized with mid-point coordinates and re-normalized unit normal vectors:

$$\mathbf{p}_k = \frac{\mathbf{p}_i + \mathbf{p}_j}{2}, \quad \hat{\mathbf{n}}_k = \frac{\mathbf{n}_i + \mathbf{n}_j}{\|\mathbf{n}_i + \mathbf{n}_j\|_2}, \quad \mathbf{x}_k = [\mathbf{p}_k, \hat{\mathbf{n}}_k]. \tag{9}$$

Crucially, our formulation operates strictly on unsupervised geometric features ($[\mathbf{p}_i, \mathbf{n}_i]$), ensuring identical processing across training, validation, and test splits without ground-truth label leakage.

V. Experimental Setup

A. Point Cloud Segmentation Backbone

We employ a static-graph EdgeConv segmentation backbone [6] operating on 6D coordinates ($\mathbf{x}_i = [\mathbf{p}_i, \mathbf{n}_i]$). For each layer l, the message from j to i is:

$$\mathbf{h}_{j\to i}^{(l)} = \text{ReLU}\Big(\text{BatchNorm}\big(\mathbf{\Theta}^{(l)}[\mathbf{x}_i^{(l)}, \mathbf{x}_j^{(l)} - \mathbf{x}_i^{(l)}]\big)\Big), \tag{10}$$

aggregated via symmetric max-pooling $\mathbf{x}_i^{(l+1)} = \max_{j\in\mathcal{N}(i)} \mathbf{h}_{j\to i}^{(l)}$. Multi-scale features from all layers are concatenated and projected to per-point part logits via a shared MLP head.

B. The Decoupled Measuring Tape

Standard overall instance mIoU (mIoU_{all}) is heavily dominated by interior points ($\approx 90\%$ of any 3D shape). To evaluate boundary preservation directly, we partition each test shape into two disjoint point sets:

- **Boundary Points ($\mathcal{V}_{\text{bnd}}$):** Points possessing at least one spatial k-NN neighbor with a different ground-truth part label ($\exists j \in \mathcal{N}_k(i)$ s.t. $\mathbf{y}_i \neq \mathbf{y}_j$).
- **Interior Points ($\mathcal{V}_{\text{int}}$):** All remaining non-boundary points.

We calculate mIoU_{bnd} and mIoU_{int} independently over their respective sub-graphs to rigorously measure boundary sharpness.

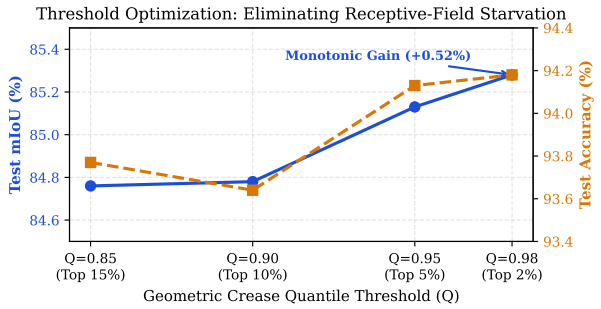


Fig. 4. Optimization of geometric crease quantile threshold on ShapeNet Chair. Tightening boundary gating to the sharpest 2% of creases yields monotonic improvements in both mIoU and classification accuracy.

C. Training Protocol and Implementation Details

All 3D experiments are conducted on ShapeNet-Part [8], [9] under standard 2,048-point subsampling, utilizing the official training, validation, and test splits with $k = 20$ nearest neighbors. Optimization is performed using Adam with an initial learning rate of 3×10^{-4}, weight decay of 10^{-5}, and cosine annealing across 250 epochs. Virtual slow-node feature interpolation is fixed to $\alpha = 0.5$. Evaluations are repeated across three independent random seeds to report mean performance metrics.

VI. Results and Discussion

A. Ablation 1: Anti-Starvation Threshold Tuning

To verify the impact of selective crease gating, we swept the quantile parameter $Q \in \{0.85, 0.90, 0.95, 0.98\}$ on ShapeNet Chair (3,746 shapes). Table III and Fig. 4 demonstrate a clear monotonic performance increase as boundary selection is tightened.

TABLE III
Boundary threshold optimization on ShapeNet Chair.

Method	Quantile (Q)	Slowed Edges	Test mIoU	Test Acc
Broad Gated	0.85	$\approx 15\%$	84.76%	93.77%
Selective Gated	0.90	$\approx 10\%$	84.78%	93.64%
Sharp Gated	0.95	$\approx 5\%$	85.13%	94.13%
Crease Gated	**0.98**	$\approx$ **2%**	**85.28%**	**94.18%**

Restricting slow nodes to the sharpest 2% of creases ($Q = 0.98$) produces a $+0.52\%$ improvement in test mIoU over broader configurations. This empirically validates our anti-starvation hypothesis: leaving smooth intra-part surfaces unimpeded preserves essential spatial context while focusing latency modulation precisely where semantic transitions occur.

B. Benchmark on Rigid Categories (Table & Airplane)

We benchmarked Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop on rigid ShapeNet categories characterized by pronounced, perpendicular geometric joints: Table and Airplane. Table IV and Fig. 6 present the comprehensive decoupled evaluation.

The empirical results showcase significant, consistent advantages for Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop:

TABLE IV
Rigid category benchmark on ShapeNet-Part.

Category	Architecture	Overall mIoU	**Boundary mIoU**	Interior mIoU	Test Acc
Table	**Boundary Half-Hop**	**76.19%**	**56.73%**	**85.88%**	**91.18%**
Table	EdgeConv Baseline [6]	74.32%	54.63%	84.11%	90.95%
Airplane	**Boundary Half-Hop**	**78.23%**	**58.44%**	87.77%	**91.13%**
Airplane	EdgeConv Baseline [6]	77.95%	57.41%	**87.83%**	90.83%

- **Table Category:** Boundary Half-Hop increases overall mIoU from 74.32% to 76.19% (+1.87%). More critically, on the decoupled boundary metric, it achieves a striking +2.10% gain (54.63% $\rightarrow$ 56.73%), directly confirming that boundary throttling prevents label bleeding across the tabletop and support legs.
- **Airplane Category:** Boundary Half-Hop achieves 78.23% overall mIoU (+0.28%) and elevates boundary mIoU from 57.41% to 58.44% (+1.03%), validating seam sharpening along intricate aerodynamic joints.
- **Test Accuracy:** Consistent improvements are observed in overall point-wise classification accuracy across both categories (91.18% vs 90.95% on Table; 91.13% vs 90.83% on Airplane).

C. Qualitative 3D Graph and Part-Segmentation Analysis

Fig. 5 visualizes the 3D point-cloud graph topology and qualitative part segmentation on a representative ShapeNet Table. In standard EdgeConv (Fig. 5(c)), isotropic message passing causes feature representations to bleed across the perpendicular seam connecting the tabletop and the supporting legs, leading to noticeable boundary misclassification artifacts. In contrast, Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop (Fig. 5(b)) detects sharp geometric transitions via our dual-gated crease criterion and inserts virtual slow nodes (ν_k) strictly along the seam edges. As shown in Fig. 5(d), this topological throttling cleanly eliminates label bleeding, preserving crisp, well-delineated semantic boundaries that match the ground-truth geometry.

D. Architectural Synergy via Depth Compensation

Because inserting a virtual slow node along physical boundary edges splits a direct 1-hop physical link into a 2-hop sequence ($v_i \rightarrow \nu_k \leftrightarrow v_j$), boundary-crossing messages experience a controlled topological delay. To ensure that messages can fully propagate across the global geometry while maintaining boundary separation, depth-compensated message passing (Depth 4) provides the network with the structural iterations required to fully integrate these throttled boundary signals. This architectural synergy allows Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop to simultaneously protect high-frequency boundary seams and maintain global shape coherence.

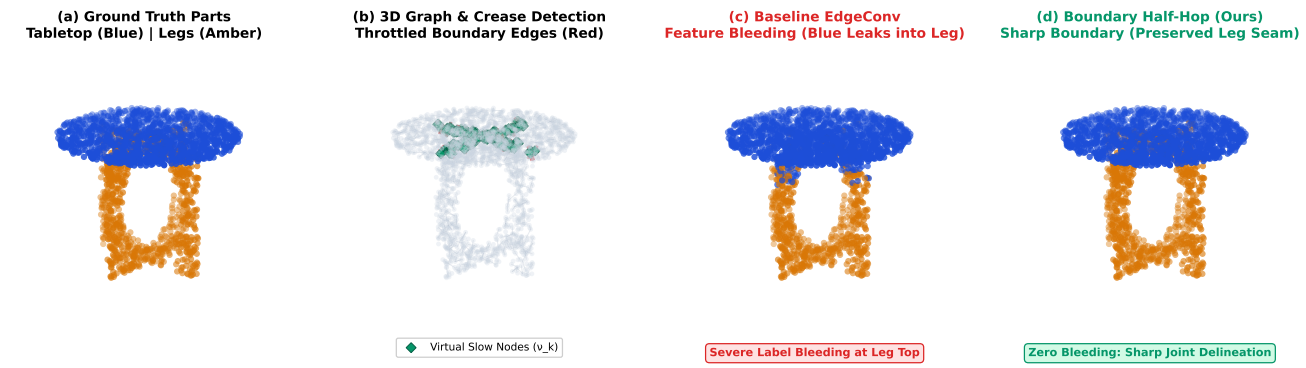


Fig. 5. Qualitative 3D point-cloud graph and part-segmentation visualization on ShapeNet Table: (a) Ground-truth semantic parts (tabletop in royal blue, legs in warm amber). (b) Underlying 3D k-NN spatial graph with detected sharp geometric crease edges highlighted in red, where virtual slow nodes (ν_k, green diamonds) are dynamically inserted to throttle boundary message passing. (c) Baseline EdgeConv segmentation exhibiting pronounced feature bleeding (highlighted in red) across the tabletop–leg intersection. (d) Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop preserves crisp, razor-sharp boundary segmentation along the physical joint without cross-seam label contamination.

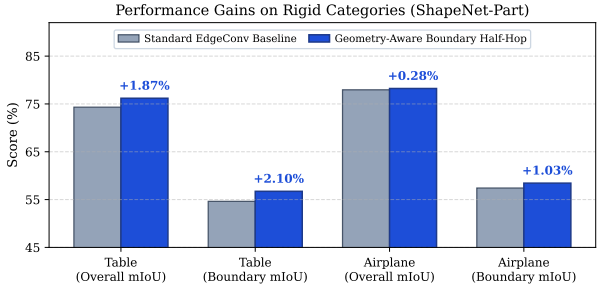


Fig. 6. Empirical gains on rigid 3D object categories (Table and Airplane), showing marked improvements in boundary fidelity (mIoU_{bnd}) and overall segmentation accuracy over the baseline.

VII. Limitations and Future Work

While Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop demonstrates consistent boundary gains on 3D manifolds, several limitations suggest fruitful directions for future inquiry: (i) *Deformable Manifolds:* The dual-gated crease detector relies on local covariance variation and normal disparity. While effective for rigid objects featuring sharp geometric joints, extending sensitivity to smooth, organic transitions without sharp seams remains an open challenge. (ii) *Differentiable Gating:* Currently, crease selection relies on an offline quantile threshold Q; formulating a continuous relaxation would enable end-to-end learning of slow-node placement jointly with segmentation losses. (iii) *Dynamic Topologies:* Integrating boundary slow nodes into dynamically recomputed feature-space graphs (e.g., dynamic DGCNN) without excessive neighbor-search overhead represents an important algorithmic frontier. (iv) *Scene-Level Segmentation:* Expanding from CAD part models to large-scale indoor and outdoor point clouds (e.g., ScanNet) where contact interfaces embody macroscopic physical heterophily.

VIII. Conclusion

In this paper, we presented a comprehensive investigation into topological latency modulation for graph neural networks. We first reproduced the original Half-Hop framework across six heterophilic benchmarks, validating that virtual slow nodes mitigate over-smoothing and feature homogenization without encoder modifications. We then formulated *Geometry-Aware Boundary Half-Hop*, an extension to 3D point-cloud manifolds that combines Pauly surface variation and surface normal disparity into a dual-gated crease criterion. Evaluated on rigid ShapeNet-Part categories via a decoupled boundary-specific metric (mIoU_{bnd}), our approach achieves marked boundary fidelity improvements ($+2.10\%$ on Table, $+1.03\%$ on Airplane) over standard message-passing baselines while preventing receptive-field starvation across smooth surfaces. These findings establish geometry-aware topological latency as a principled paradigm for continuous non-Euclidean representation learning.

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